

‘Free’ buses: €100 million a year?

The Shift’s headline figure and its gridlock claim, tested against official statistics

THE CLAIM

“‘Free’ public transport reaches €100 million a year in subsidies as traffic gridlock worsens”

The Shift News (Ivan Camilleri), 26 February 2026, headline

Body: the system “cost taxpayers almost €100 million in 2025, according to figures tabled in Parliament”.

We could not read the parliamentary reply behind the money; the euro figures are second-hand (see report).

VERDICT

NOT SUBSTANTIATED

*Nearer €93 million on its own numbers;
the link to congestion is not tested.*

SUPPORTED

LARGELY
SUPPORTED

NOT
SUBSTANTIATED

MISLEADING

CONTRADICTED

MAIN RESULTS

+1.1 pt

Congestion, Valletta area

TomTom’s congestion level 49.2% to 50.3%, 2024 to 2025; speed down 0.5 km/h. Two years, one area.

+5.8%

Passenger cars since 2022

Eurostat: 317,234 to 335,693 cars by 2025. Population grew 10.4%, so cars per 1,000 residents fell from 610 to 585.

3 payments

Add to less than the headline

The article’s own three 2025 payments sum to under €100m, and one is for buying buses. Second-hand: replies not read.

Untested

Did free travel fail?

No counterfactual in the data. Rising payments and rising cars are both true; cause is not shown.

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Replies or accounts we could read

parlament.mt, finance.gov.mt and Transport Malta refused our access.

FAIR TO SAY

Payments have risen every year in the figures reported, and cars and congestion have edged up. What is not shown is the €100 million or the cause.

WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT

☐ The Minister’s replies, itemised for 2024 and 2025.

☐ 2025 outturn for the PSO and free-travel lines.

☐ Payments by year on one basis.

☐ Traffic counts or vehicle-km, 2019–2025.